

The Noble Great Goddess Śrī: A Prophecy

Ārya Śrī Mahādevī Vyākaraṇa · Toh 739 · Derge Kangyur

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Toh 739 in the Kangyur is a canonical Buddhist sūtra known in Sanskrit as the Ārya Śrī Mahādevī Vyākaraṇa and in Tibetan as "The Noble Great Goddess Śrī: A Prophecy." As its title suggests, it belongs to the genre of vyākaraṇa, or prophetic revelation texts, in which the Buddha delivers a formal prophecy concerning a divine or bodhisattva figure — here the Great Goddess Śrī, a deity associated with auspiciousness and good fortune. The text opens with the Buddha residing in the pure land of Sukhāvatī in the company of a great assembly of bodhisattva mahāsattvas, including Avalokiteśvara, Vajrapāṇi, Kṣitigarbha, and others, setting the stage for a solemn declaration concerning the goddess. It belongs to the broader class of dhāraṇī and tantra-adjacent sūtras within the Kangyur, reflecting the tradition's interest in the protective and salvific powers of great feminine divine figures.

Qualities fathomless and without end. Namo Bhagavate Brahmani. Namaḥ Sarasvatyai Devi — siddhayantu mantra-pādaṃ Brahmānumantra svāhā. Here ends the Praise to the Glorious Goddess of Melodious Sound.

In the language of India: Ārya Śrī Mahādevī Vyākaraṇa. In the language of Tibet: The Noble Great Goddess Śrī: A Prophecy.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was in Sukhāvatī, together with this great assembly of bodhisattvas — namely, the bodhisattva mahāsattva noble Avalokiteśvara, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāsthāmaprāpta, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Sarvanīvaraṇaviṣkambhin, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Kṣitigarbha, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Samantabhadra, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Ākāśagarbha, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Vajrapāṇi, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Sarvabhayavigatī, and likewise the bodhisattva mahāsattva Śubhamaṅgaladhāriṇī, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Puṇyalakṣaṇadhāriṇī, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Sūryacandra, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Jagatpāla, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Tīrthikamaṅgaladhāriṇī, the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mañjuśrī Kumārabhūta, and all the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas of the Fortunate Aeon — and they were all assembled together.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Avalokiteśvara approached the Blessed One, and having come before him, prostrated with his head at the feet of the Blessed One and sat down to one side.

The Great Goddess Śrī also approached the Blessed One, and having come before him, prostrated with her head at the feet of the Blessed One, circumambulated him one hundred thousand times, prostrated likewise with her head to those bodhisattva mahāsattvas dwelling in Sukhāvatī, and sat down to one side.

Then the Blessed One, adorned with countless hundreds of thousands of merits, fully surrounded by tens of millions of Tathāgatas, was praised and extolled by Śakra (Indra, lord of the gods), by Brahmā, and by all the world-guardians. The Blessed One looked upon the Great Goddess Śrī and, speaking in the voice of Great Brahmā, addressed the bodhisattva mahāsattva Avalokiteśvara in these words:

"Avalokiteśvara, whoever among kings, ministers, monks, nuns, laymen, laywomen, brahmins, the warrior caste (kṣatriyas), the merchant caste, or the common people bears this praise called The One Hundred and Eight Names of the Great Goddess Śrī, Free of Stain, so Renowned — in the realm of that king of the warrior caste, all fears for those sentient beings, all epidemic disease, and all harm shall be pacified; thieves, the deceitful, and all fears from humans and non-humans shall not arise; and all wealth, grain, treasuries, and granaries shall flourish abundantly. In the home of that king of the warrior caste, prosperity shall assuredly dwell."

Then those bodhisattva mahāsattvas spoke these words: "Blessed One, this that you have graciously proclaimed is excellent, excellent! It is excellent indeed. Such are the qualities and benefits that belong to those who hold the names of the Great Goddess Śrī and who, upon hearing them, strive to accomplish them."

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva, the noble Avalokiteśvara, spoke these words to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, where did the Great Goddess Śrī plant her roots of virtue?"

The Blessed One declared: "The Great Goddess Śrī planted roots of virtue in as many Tathāgatas as there are grains of sand in the river Ganges. In a past age gone by, in a world system called Arisen from Jewels, two Tathāgatas appeared in the world: the Tathāgata named Ocean of Qualities of Jeweled Flowers, Vaiḍūrya and Golden Mountain, and the Tathāgata named Beautiful in

Color, Splendor of Golden Light. The Great Goddess Śrī also planted roots of virtue in many other Tathāgatas besides these.

These names of the Tathāgatas, moreover, are what cause the roots of virtue of that Great Goddess Śrī to increase, to be accomplished, and to be constantly attended upon. Here in this present context, these names bring about the authentic recitation of the Great Goddess Śrī; they dispel all evil; they eliminate all misdeeds and transgressions; they purify the entire body from defilement; they gather and increase wealth and grain; they cut off poverty; they summon and attract all gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, and great serpents; they pacify all epidemic disease, harm, conflict, discord, disturbance, and strife; and they accomplish the six perfections.

They are as follows:

Homage to the Tathāgata Dense Splendor.

Homage to the Tathāgata Ocean of Qualities of Jeweled Flowers, Vaiḍūrya and Golden Mountain, Beautiful in Color, Splendor of Golden Light.

Homage to the Tathāgata Auspicious Splendor of All the Tīrthika Gates of the Ganges.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Light of Stars, Majestic Sandalwood Flowers.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of Omnipresent Light, Victorious in Battle.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Maṇḍala of the Radiance of the Ocean of Qualities.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Power of the Victory Banner of the Dharma's Miraculous Display.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Fragrant Light of Tranquil Starlight.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Body that Pacifies the Intentions of Sentient Beings.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Radiance of the Ocean of Aspirations.

Blessed One, homage to the Tathāgata Splendor Named Most Thoroughly Renowned.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Abode of the Irreversible Precious Wheel.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Transcendent Light of the Solar Disc.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of Perfect and Complete Immeasurable Diligence.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Radiance of Immeasurable Supreme Gold.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Melodious Sound of All the Branches of Speech.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Crest of Immeasurable Rays of the Lamp of Wisdom.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Mountain of the Ascetic Rites of Akaniṣṭha.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of Brahmā.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Great Lord.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Light of Sun and Moon.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the King of the Light of Profound Dharma.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Lovely Light of the Lamp of Space."

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Crest of Sunlight.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Lamp of Incense.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor Arisen from the Essence of the Ocean.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Melodious Thunder of the Emanated Dragon.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Arrangement of All Dharma Radiance.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of One Born Like the King of Trees.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Mountain of Radiating Jewel-Light.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Ocean of Radiating Wisdom-Light.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Power of the Great Aspiration.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Great Cloud.

Homage to the Tathāgata King of the Crest of Mindfulness.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the King Whose Victory Banner is the Crest of the Sense Faculties.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor of the Gatherer of All Wealth and Grain.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor Who Leads to Peace.

Homage to the Tathāgata Splendor Who Summons All Excellences.

These names of the Tathāgatas are to be taken up in proper order, memorized, and recited. Whoever does so — whether a son of good family or a daughter of good family — will generate merit in very great abundance.

All the Tathāgatas then prophesied to the Great Goddess Śrī, saying: "Great Goddess Śrī, in a future time, in a world-realm called Greatly Magnificent, Adorned with Precious Jewels, you will be the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly and fully awakened Buddha known as Śrī Arisen from Precious Jewels. That world-realm will be adorned with a wealth of divine precious jewels of every kind. The Tathāgata himself will illuminate that world-realm, and the bodhisattvas dwelling in that world-realm will themselves radiate light and will have immeasurable life. From the sky itself will come the sounds of the buddha, the Dharma, and the Saṅgha. All the bodhisattvas who will be born in that buddha-field will be born from pure lotus hearts." This was the prophecy that was given.

Now, what are the twelve continuous praises that constitute the hymn called Like a Hundred and Eight Unstained Names? Listen well to the names of the fearless Great Goddess Śrī, Avalokiteśvara the Sovereign Lord:

She who is empowered by all the Tathāgatas. She who is empowered by all the gods. Mother of all the Tathāgatas. Mother of all the gods. Splendor of all the Tathāgatas. Splendor of all the bodhisattvas. Splendor of all the noble śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Splendor of Brahmā, Viṣṇu, and the Great Lord Śiva. Splendor of all the gods and the rest. Splendor that is present in all places. Splendor of all gods, nāgas, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, and great serpents. Splendor of all knowledge-mantra holders, of Vajrapāṇi, and of all vajra-holders. Splendor of the four and five world-protectors. Splendor of the eight planets and the twenty-eight lunar mansions.

Oṃ. Daughter of the Sun, or: Splendor of the Four Vidyās, the mothers. The Auspicious One. Mother of sentient beings. The Queen. The Utterly Victorious One. The Gaṅgā. Mother of all tīrthikas. Mother of all auspiciousness. The Splendor who renders one stainless. She who seizes all wrongdoing. She who bestows pride. Splendor of the Moon. Splendor of the Sun. Splendor of all the planets. She who rides a lion. She who is covered by a hundred thousand supreme lotuses. Lotus. She who is born from the lotus.

She who abides on the lotus. She who holds the lotus. She who is endowed with the lotus. She who is adorned with a garland of blazing precious-jewel segments. She who bestows wealth. The White One, the Great White One. She of white hands. She who holds all auspiciousness. She whose body has gathered all merit. Daughter of wisdom's companion. She who has a hundred thousand hands. She who has a hundred thousand eyes. She who has a hundred thousand heads. She who wears a crown of jewels of every variety. She of beautiful form. She who embodies the form of all. The Renowned One. The Supremely Renowned One. The Peaceful One. She whose hair is pure as a cloud. She who is beautiful as the moon. The Virtuous One. She who creates virtue. Splendor who is present before all sentient beings. The noble Splendor of Flowers, the Mistress of Flowers. Splendor of all the kings of mountains, Meru and all the rest. Splendor of all rivers and lakes. Splendor of all waters and oceans. Splendor present before all tīrthikas. Splendor of all medicines, grasses, forests, wealth, and grain. She who bestows gold. She who bestows food and drink. She of luminous clarity. The Radiant One. She of pure body. She who wields sovereignty over all Tathāgatas. Splendor present before all the hosts of gods. Splendor of Yama, the water deity, evil spirits, Śakra (Indra), and all the rest. She who gives. The Prosperous One. The Majestic One. She who possesses majesty. The Excellent One. The Abundant One. She who fully flourishes. The Seeing One. She who is the Splendor of the Dharma. She who rests upon Viṣṇu. She who abides on the white lotus (kumuda). The Yakṣa Queen. She who bestows patience. She who is the abode of power and prowess. She who holds the hand of all purifications and all auspiciousness. She who terrifies all inauspiciousness. Splendor who gathers all merit. Splendor of all lands and all kings. Splendor of all the kings of vidyādhara mantra-holders. Splendor of all spirits, yakṣas, rākṣasas, hungry ghosts, flesh-eaters, kumbhāṇḍas, and great serpents. Splendor of the abodes of the gods and of all gods. Splendor of all recitation, that which is to be recited, fire offerings, that which is to be offered in fire, and all auspiciousness. The

Radiant One. The Supremely Joyful One. She who transforms through fortune. Splendor who is praised with joy by all sages. Supreme Splendor, chief over all the abodes of all women. Supreme among all Splendors of all kinnarī (half-human celestial maidens) and all female asuras. She who dwells in a place utterly beyond reproach. The Pleasing One. She who brings contentment. She who is pleasing to evil spirits. Splendor of the King of Dharma.

Oṃ. Look upon us from all suffering and liberate us! Grant us liberation! May all the accumulations of merit be made fully manifest for me — svāhā.

Oṃ gaṅgā sarvatīrtha-mukhe svāhā. Oṃ sarvavidye svāhā. Sarvamaṅgaladhāraṇī svāhā. Caturvade sarvanakṣatra grāhaga nāhaga nādhāmūrtaye svāhā. Brahmāya svāhā. Viṣṇave svāhā. Rudrāya svāhā. Viśvamukhāya svāhā.

Oṃ griṇi griṇa sarvakāryasādhani sini sini āvāha deva hā. Vaiśravaṇāya svāhā. Suvarṇa dhana-dhanya ākarṣaṇye svāhā. Sarvapūṇyākarṣaṇye svāhā. Śrīhevate ākarṣaṇye svāhā. Sarvapāpanaśamāi svāhā. Sarvālakṣmīpraśamanye svāhā. Sarvatathāgatābhiṣekāye svāhā. Sarvadevatābhimukhaśriye āyurbalapūrṇakarāye svāhā. Sarvavidyāmaṅgalahastāya svāhā. Simhavāhanāye svāhā. Padmasambhūtāye svāhā. Sarvakṛttikākhoḍavaniśamāi svāhā.

Fearless Avalokiteśvara! Whoever hears the great goddess's name Śrī — she who removes all sins and wrongdoing, who destroys all misdeeds, who gathers all merit, who removes all inauspiciousness, who gathers all splendor, well-being, and every good fortune — these and

these names of Tathāgatas — whoever holds them and recites them shall rise early in the morning, purify themselves, offer flowers and incense to all the buddhas, then offer sandalwood incense to the great goddess Śrī and recite this text. By so doing, that person will behold all splendor, will attain every happiness and joy of mind, all the gods will protect, shelter, and guard them, and all their wishes and aims will be fulfilled.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the bodhisattva Fearless Avalokiteśvara, together with the great goddess Śrī herself, and that retinue possessed of all qualities, and the world with its gods, humans, asuras, and gandharvas, all rejoiced and praised what the Blessed One had taught.

This concludes the noble sūtra "The Great Goddess Śrī: A Prophecy."

Translator's Notes

- The Sanskrit dharaṇī phrases at the opening are transliterated mantra material and are rendered as-is per convention; their internal syntax is devotional-liturgical rather than propositional.

Several of the bodhisattva names in the assembly list appear in their Tibetan descriptive forms rather than as established Sanskrit proper names. "Mahāsthāmaprāpta" renders the Tibetan "mtḥy chen thob pa" (he who has attained great power), which is the standard Tibetan equivalent of that name. The remaining names — Sarvabhayavigatī, Śubhamaṅgaladhāriṇī, Puṇyalakṣaṇadhāriṇī, Jagatpāla, and Tīrthikamaṅgaladhāriṇī — are back-reconstructed from the Tibetan; they do not correspond to universally attested Sanskrit names in the canon, though the reconstructions are straightforward.

- The phrase rendered "Tīrthika Gates of the Ganges" for गङ्गातीर्थागारः is unusual: गङ्गातीर्थ ordinarily means "tīrthika" (non-Buddhist adherent), but in the context of a Tathāgata name it likely refers to the sacred river fords or banks of the Ganges (the literal meaning of Sanskrit tīrtha, from which tīrthika derives), i.e., "auspicious splendor of all the sacred fords of the Ganges." Either reading is defensible; the ford interpretation is contextually more natural for a buddha epithet.

The name སྐུ་རྒྱལ་གྱི་སངས་རྒྱལ་པོ་འཛོམས་ཀྱི་ཕོ་བྲང་ཆེན་པོ་ is rendered "Splendor of the Mountain of the Ascetic Rites of Akaniṣṭha." འཛོམས་ཀྱི་ཕོ་བྲང་ཆེན་པོ་ is Akaniṣṭha (the highest pure-abode heaven), and སྐུ་རྒྱལ་ is "mountain / Sumeru." The compound is dense and the exact intended referent of the full name is uncertain.

- [illegible]

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.